Alex McFarlane | 2026 | Nasty Stuff, Outlier Heater

333 pitches · 21 outings (2 postseason) · .280 wOBA · 26% K · 8.2% BB · four-seam 99.4 mph / 2544 rpm

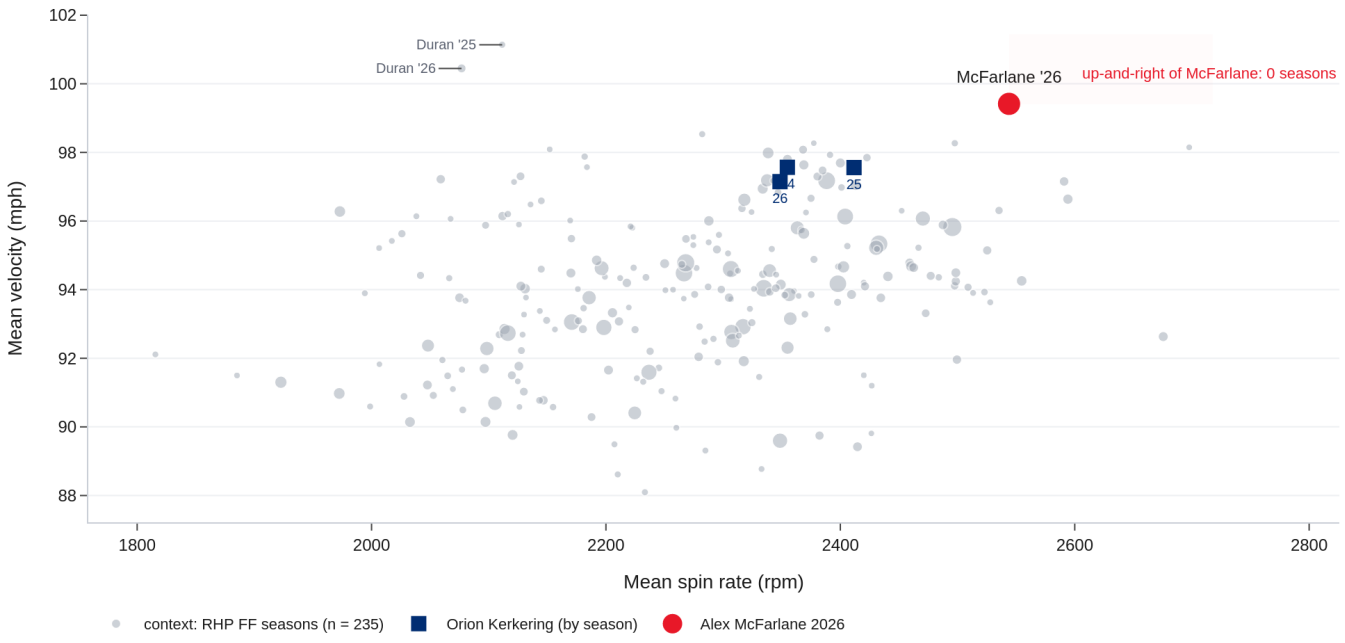
Read this first. Data through 2026-10-01 (house log; T-1 normal). The commentary is the client's own narrative, kept verbatim; 5 fragments are corrected where a receipt disagrees, each marked † and listed in the claims ledger. MLB sample: 333 pitches, 85 PA across 21 outings (19 regular season + 2 Wild Card): rates are directional, and PA is printed beside them. AAA is a supporting tier, never blended. Entity lock: MLBAM 686934 (id rows = name rows = 333).

The bottom line

- **The fastball is one of one.** 99.4 mph and 2544 rpm on average: 99th and 97th percentile among 239 righty four-seam seasons thrown in Phillies games since 2015, and no other season sits at or above him on both (CONFIRMED).
- **The year reconciles exactly to the client's numbers:** .280 wOBA, .633 OPS, 26% K, 8.2% BB, 22:7 K:BB. xwOBA .299.
- **Lefties were the clean side** (K 33.3%, 1 walk in 39 PA; slider 38.1% whiff / 50.0% chase). **Righties hit .179 but hit it hard** (41.9% HH, 9.7% barrel) and drew 6 of his 7 walks.
- **The Bridge to Duran was real, and late:** 4 lead-with-Duran-to-follow outings, all from 2026-08-31 on (PARTLY on the pre-registered bar).
- **Stretch (S-1):** through 21 outings each he missed more bats and walked fewer than Orion Kerkering did; Kerkering allowed far softer contact and arrived into October.

One of one: velocity and spin, pitcher-season averages

RHP four-seam seasons in Phillies games, ≥ 100 FF (n = 239). None sits up-and-right of McFarlane.



1 · Hand-in-hand with Kerkering

Commentary. Time to recap Alex McFarlane's 2026 season. Frankly, it has to go hand-in-hand with the guy who was drafted in the round following McFarlane back in 2022. A fellow right-handed college reliever from Florida, Orion Kerkering. Taken in the 5th round out of South Florida†, Kerk was rushed to the majors back in 2023 to pitch in leverage situations for several iterations of this ballclub.

The data. Both 2022 draftees out of Florida colleges (McFarlane, 4th round, Miami; Kerkering, 5th, South Florida). Kerkering's first 21 MLB outings ran 2023-09-24 to 2024-05-13 and included 7 postseason games; McFarlane's ran 2026-07-22 to 2026-09-30 with 2. HP-11b corrects the school.

2 · Time to ascend

Commentary. Now it was Alex McFarlane's time to ascend to the big league bullpen. During the fateful weekend in Atlanta which cost Rob Thomson his job, Alex McFarlane sat in the Phillies bullpen. Ready to be used. He was not needed.

The data. Recalled from Double-A Reading on 4/24 before the Atlanta series; Thomson was dismissed 4/28 (carry-ins CI-1, CI-2). The log has no McFarlane pitch until 2026-07-22: he sat, and was not needed.

3 · 333 pitches, 21 outings, one AAA detour

Commentary. McFarlane dominated AA for most of 2026, I do not have statcast data for that. I do have data from his brief stint in AAA along with all 333 of his major league pitches across 21 outings including two postseason games.

The data. AAA is a supporting tier: 4 Lehigh Valley outings 2026-07-29 to 2026-08-08, 73 pitches, 8 K and 2 BB in 17 PA, 32% whiffs. Stints: MLB debut 2026-07-22 (12 pitches), AAA, then MLB from 2026-08-11 through the Wild Card. MLB evidence: 333 pitches, 21 outings (19 regular season + 2 Wild Card).

Stint	Tier	First	Last	Outings	Pitches
1	MLB	2026-07-22	2026-07-22	1	12
2	AAA (supporting)	2026-07-29	2026-08-08	4	73
3	MLB	2026-08-11	2026-09-30	20	321

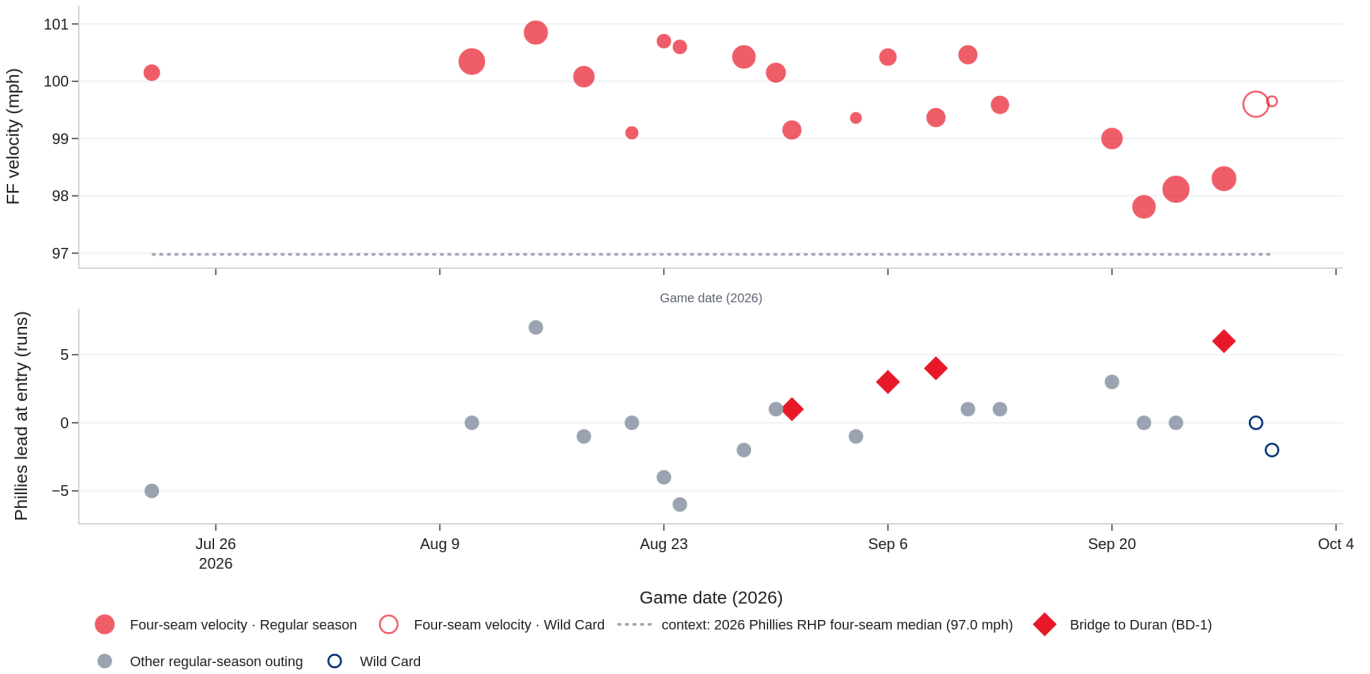
4 · The Bridge to Duran

Commentary. McFarlane emerged as a key plank in the Bridge to Duran, the highwire act conducted by Don Mattingly when protecting a lead down the stretch for this ballclub. McFarlane's presence in the "Circle of Trust" belied his inexperience. His eye-popping stuff plays against big league hitters. Improved command in 2026 brought improved results with solid underlying metrics.

The data. BD-1: 4 of 19 regular-season outings came with a lead and Duran to follow, the first on 2026-08-31; he left with the lead intact in 3 of 4. He entered with the lead 9 times. 'Emerged … down the stretch' fits; 'key plank' is ahead of four outings (PARTLY). Command can't be compared to a prior year (no pre-2026 pitch data; NOT OBSERVABLE).

Twenty-one outings: the heater and the game state

Top: four-seam velocity by outing. Bottom: Phillies lead when he entered; ◆ = bridge to Duran (BD-1).



Down the stretch the heater came down a tick: four-seam 100.0 mph in his first 16 regular-season outings, 98.1 in the last 3 (sinker 99.4 → 98.0); 99.6 in the Wild Card. Descriptive, not graded.

5 · His overall year

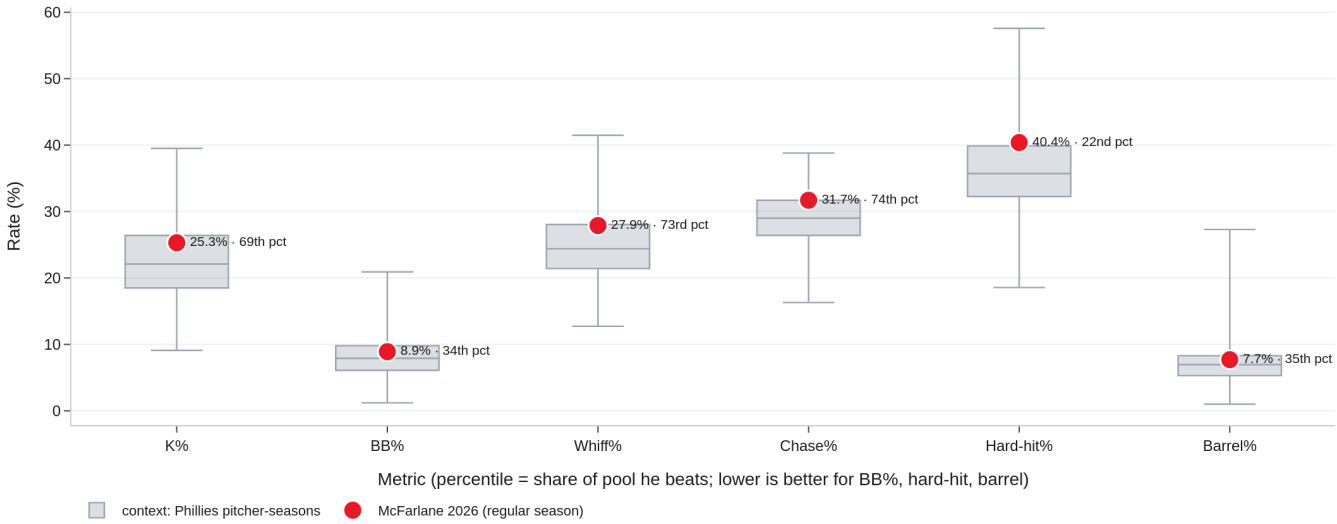
Commentary. First we take a look at his overall year. He pitched to a .280 wOBA (good!) and .633 OPS (solid!). Decent chunk of hard hits and barrels, but very strong whiff in total and good chase. Pointing to quality stuff. 26% K and 8.2% BB are good. The ratio just exceeding 3:1 is quite good.

The data. Exact: .280 wOBA, .633 OPS, 25.9% K, 8.2% BB, 22:7 K:BB. Against 258 Phillies pitcher-seasons since 2015 (regular season only): whiff 27.9% = 73rd pct, chase 31.7% = 74th, hard-hit 40.4% (pool median 35.7%). xwOBA .299 sits a touch above the .280 wOBA: results ran slightly ahead of contact quality.

Pitches	Outings	PA	wOBA	xwOBA	OPS	BA / OBP / SLG	K%	BB%	K:BB	Whiff	Chase	Hard-hit	Barrel
333	21	85	**.280**	.299	**.633**	.221 / .282 / .351	25.9%	8.2%	22:7	29.1%	33.5%	41.1%	8.9%

His overall year, against every Phillies pitcher-season since 2015

Regular season, ≥ 150 pitches (n = 258). Boxes = middle 50%. Red = McFarlane 2026.



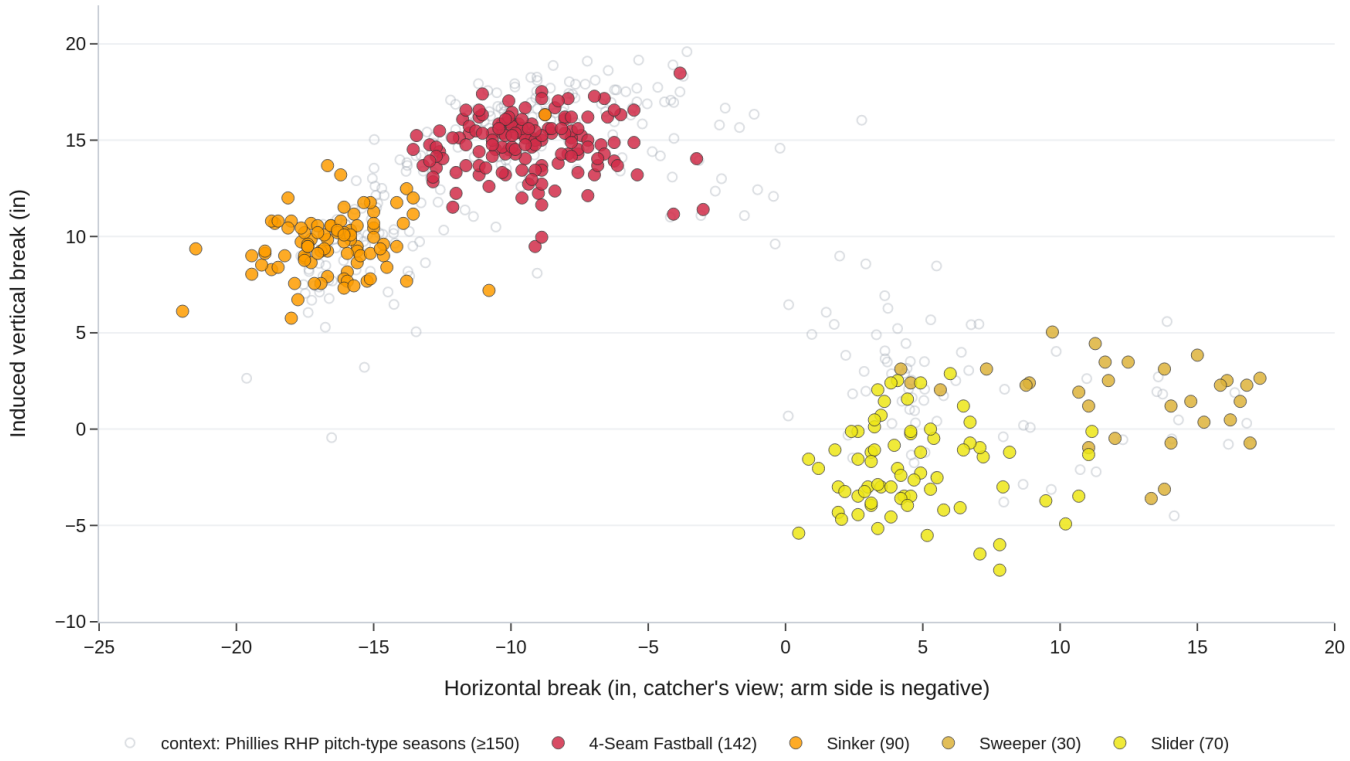
6 · The pitch plot

Commentary. Then we look at his pitch plot which is... hard to contextualize. Lots of FF that ride between 12 and 18 inches and run about 9 inches†. His sinker runs up to 18 inches. Bullet slider angles nicely off his FF which likely explains the deception to lefties. Speeds them up with heaters up and out over the plate. Follows that with a hammer slider that looks the same out of the hand before falling off the table. Sweeper sweeps at least a foot but is fairly flat, but can tunnel off his sinker when on.

The data. FF: 12.9–16.5 in of ride (10th–90th pct), 9.5 in of run (median). SI: 16.4 in of run, 18.6 in at the 90th pct. SL: 4.7 in sweep, -2.0 in IVB (bullet-adjacent: BS-1r draws the line at 4.0 / 4.0). ST: 12.9 in sweep, 2.3 in IVB. The log tags one slider (SL, 70 pitches, IVB -4.7 to 1.2 in): the 'bullet' and the 'hammer' are one pitch type here. FF to lefties: 42% upper third or above the zone. The Stuff-model subtitle is the client's read (no stuff model in the plane).

Alex McFarlane Pitch Plot

Velocity is stronger than shape in his Stuff model (client's read) · catcher's view, inches; gray = Phillies RHP pitch-type seasons



Pitch	n	Usage	Velo (mph)	Spin (rpm)	IVB in (10th / 50th / 90th)	Run/sweep in, abs (10th / 50th / 90th)
4-Seam Fastball	142	42.8%	99.4 (max 102.2)	2544	12.9 / 14.9 / 16.5	6.6 / 9.5 / 12.1
Sinker	90	27.1%	99.2 (max 101.6)	2494	7.7 / 9.5 / 11.5	14.5 / 16.4 / 18.6
Slider	70	21.1%	87.1 (max 89.1)	2806	-4.7 / -2.2 / 1.2	2.1 / 4.2 / 7.8
Sweeper	30	9.0%	86.5 (max 89.6)	2882	-0.7 / 2.3 / 3.5	7.2 / 12.9 / 16.6

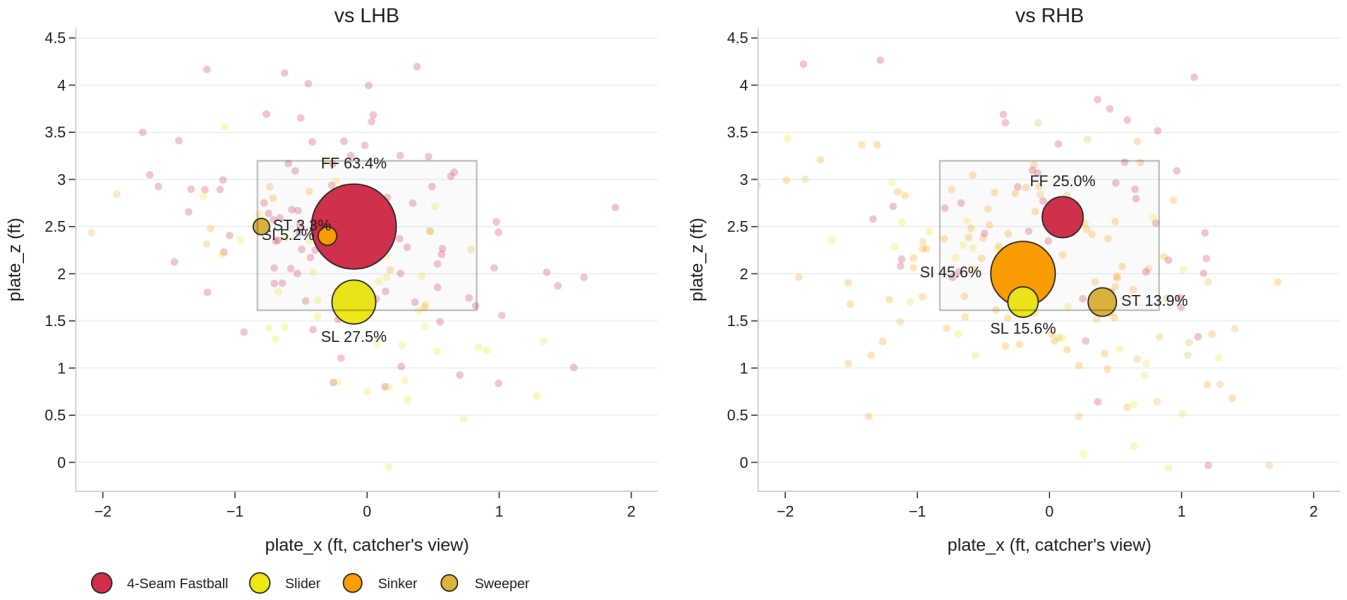
7 · Pitch maps: approach by handedness

Commentary. Now we look at pitch maps to gauge approach against left-handed batters and right-handed batters. Callouts at the stand level include: Against LHB, quality K Rate (33%) and Elite Walks Rate (2.6%)†. While against RHB: Diverse pitch mix | Just .179 BAA but lots of hard contact in the underlyings (41.9% HH, 9.7% Barrel)†.

The data. vs LHB 39 PA: K 33.3%, BB 2.6% (1 walk). vs RHB 46 PA: BAA .179, HH 41.9%, barrel 9.7%, and 6 of his 7 walks (BB 13.0%).

Pitch Map

vs LHB: 63.4% FF + 27.5% SL | Elite K Rate (33%) and Limits Walks (2.6% BB Rate)† · vs RHB: 45.6% SI + 25% FF + 15.6% SL + 13.9% ST | Just .179 BAA but lots of hard contact in the underlyings



Split	PA	Pitches	BA	wOBA	xwOBA	K%	BB%	Whiff	Chase	Hard-hit	Barrel
vs LHB	39	153	.263	.274	.257	33.3%	2.6%	35.5%	34.3%	40.0%	8.0%
vs RHB	46	180	.179	.285	.336	19.6%	13.0%	23.2%	33.0%	41.9%	9.7%

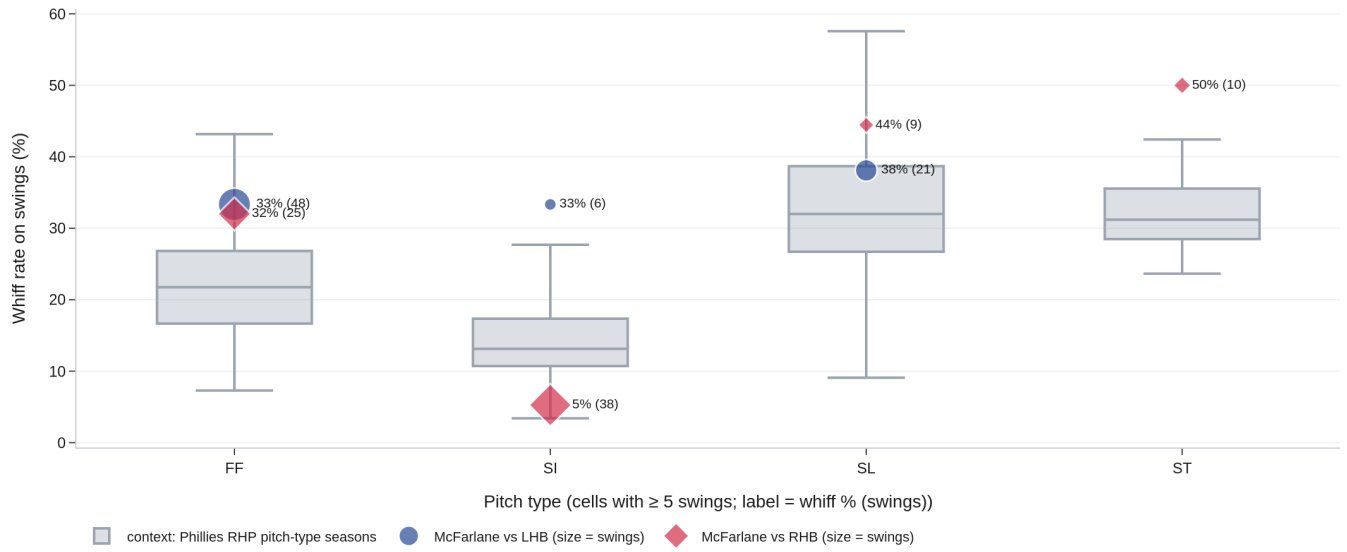
8 · His pitches against each batter handedness

Commentary. So then we look at his pitches against each batter handedness. Plus SL to LHB: 38% Whiff/50% Chase. FF gets 32% Whiff on Swings to RHB. (33% whiff vs LHB).

The data. SL v LHB 38.1% whiff on 21 swings, 50.0% chase; FF v RHB 32.0% (25 swings), v LHB 33.3% (48). Every cell is under 50 swings: directional. The sinker to righties draws contact (5.3% whiff, 38 swings).

Pitch Map with Commentary

Plus SL to LHB: 38% Whiff/50% Chase. FF gets 32% Whiff on Swings to RHB. (33% whiff vs LHB).



Batter	Pitch	Usage (n)	Swings	Whiff	Chase	Putaway	PA ended
L	FF	63.4% (97)	48	33.3%	27.3%	26.9%	21
L	SL	27.5% (42)	21	38.1%	50.0%	26.7%	13
L	SI	5.2% (8)	6	33.3%	100.0%	100.0%	4
L	ST	3.3% (5)	1	100.0%	—	33.3%	1
R	SI	45.6% (82)	38	5.3%	28.9%	20.0%	25
R	FF	25.0% (45)	25	32.0%	36.0%	16.0%	10
R	SL	15.6% (28)	9	44.4%	30.0%	12.5%	5
R	ST	13.9% (25)	10	50.0%	40.0%	27.3%	6

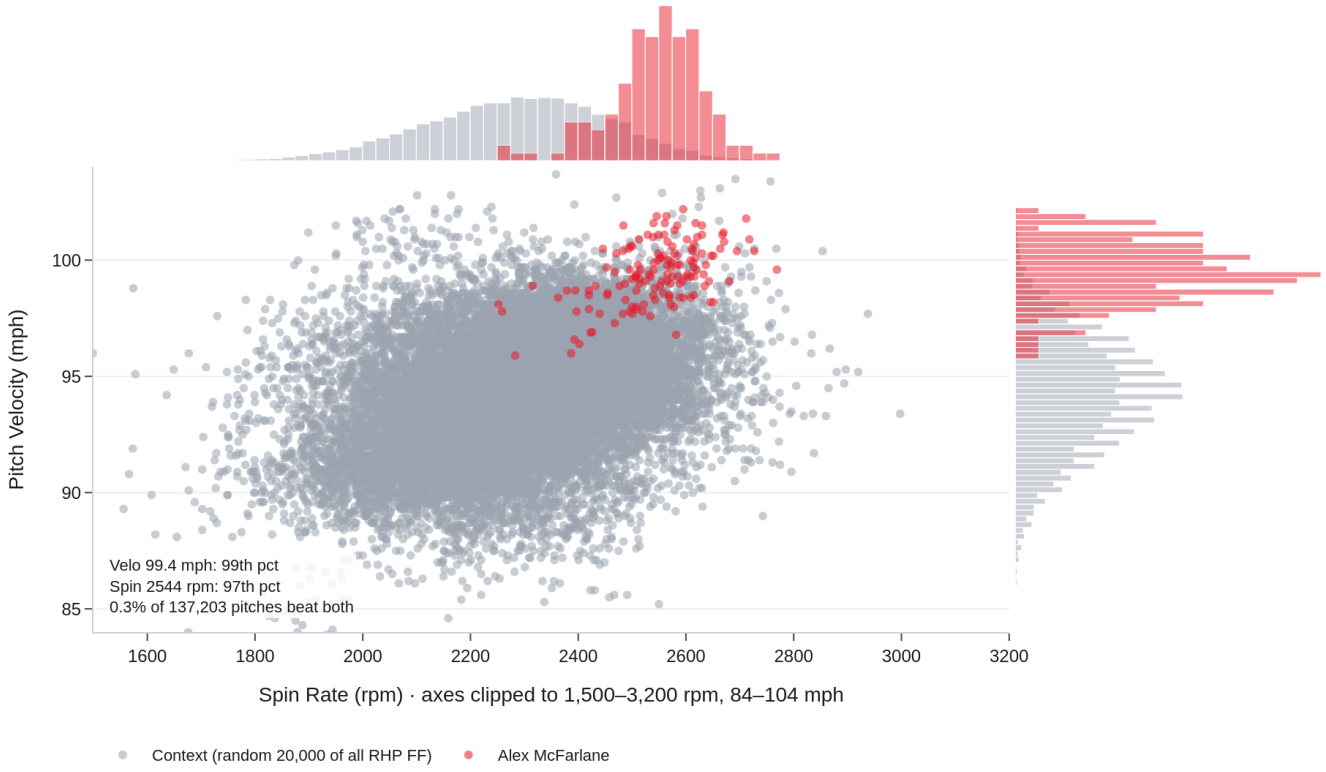
9 · The outlier fastball

Commentary. Which is indicating that he has an outlier fastball. So we build a graph to contextualize against other right-handed four-seam fastballs either thrown by Phillies pitchers or to Phillies batters since 2015. McFarlane has elite spin and elite velocity. His fastball is an outlier.

The data. FO-1: 99.4 mph (99th pct, #3 of 239 pitcher-seasons) and 2544 rpm (97th pct, #6). No other RHP four-seam season thrown in a Phillies game since 2015 (≥ 100 FF) sits at or above him on both. Pitch level: 0.3% of 137,203 righty four-seamers beat his average velocity and spin together.

Pitch Velocity as a function of Spin Rate

Righty Four-Seam Fastballs thrown in any Phillies game since 2015. Alex McFarlane throws an outlier Four-Seam Fastball.



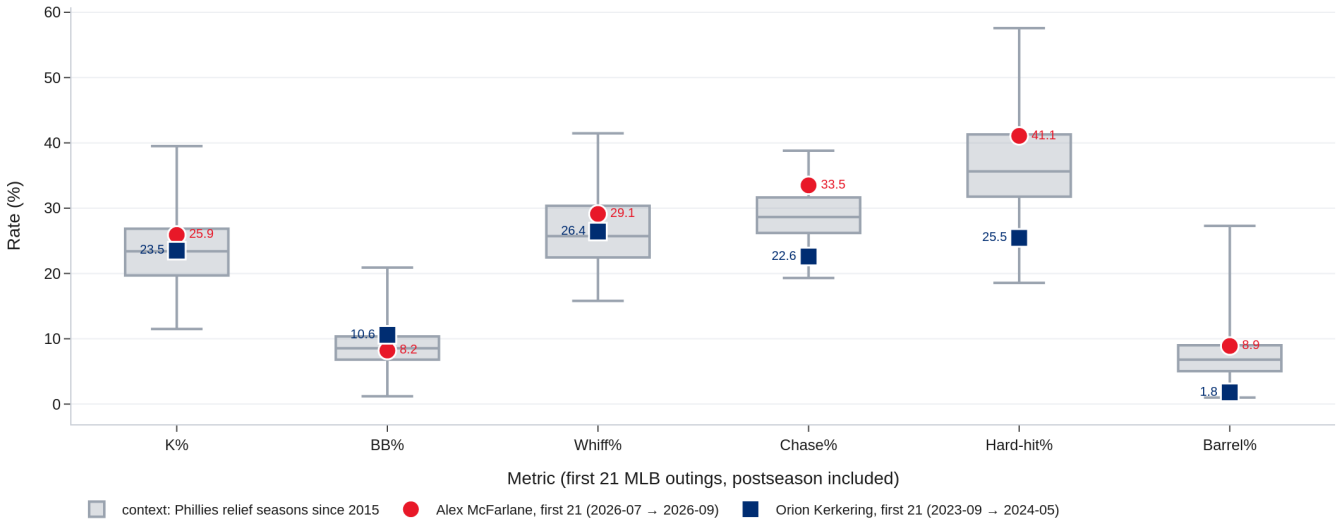
10 · Stretch S-1 (posed by the organization): draft-class twins

S-1 (posed by the org, built): through 21 MLB outings each, McFarlane .280 wOBA / .299 xwOBA, 25.9% K, 8.2% BB, 41.1% hard-hit, 99.4 mph four-seam; Kerkering .258 / .277, 23.5% K, 10.6% BB, 25.5% hard-hit, 97.6 mph. Kerkering arrived into

October (7 of his first 21 were postseason); McFarlane arrived into a pennant race (2). McFarlane missed more bats and walked fewer; Kerkering allowed far softer contact.

Draft-class twins: the first 21 MLB outings

McFarlane 2026 vs Kerkering 2023–24 (postseason included). Boxes = Phillies relief seasons since 2015.



Pitcher	Window	Outings (post)	PA	wOBA	xwOBA	K%	BB%	Whiff	Chase	Hard-hit	Barrel	FF mph	Late & close entries
Alex McFarlane	2026-07-22 → 2026-09-30	21 (2)	85	.280	.299	25.9%	8.2%	29.1%	33.5%	41.1%	8.9%	99.4	9
Orion Kerkering	2023-09-24 → 2024-05-13	21 (7)	85	.258	.277	23.5%	10.6%	26.4%	22.6%	25.5%	1.8%	97.6	8

Late & close = entered in the 7th or later with the Phillies between one run down and three up (FN-1 descriptive; not graded).

Claims ledger (bars filed in the BID before grading)

11 CONFIRMED, 7 PARTLY, 1 CORRECTED, 1 NOT OBSERVABLE. ⟨original → corrected⟩ marks a registered correction.

HP	Claim (client's words)	Evidence	Verdict	Correction
HP-01	all 333 of his major league pitches across 21 outings including two postseason games	333 pitches / 21 outings / 2 postseason games	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-02	.280 wOBA (good!) and .633 OPS (solid!)	wOBA 0.280 · OPS 0.633	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-03	26% K and 8.2% BB … ratio just exceeding 3:1	K 25.9% · BB 8.2% · K:BB 22:7 = 3.14	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-04	Decent chunk of hard hits and barrels, but very strong whiff in total and good chase	regular season vs 258 Phillies pitcher-seasons (CX-1): whiff 27.9% = 73th pct (bar 75th); chase 31.7% = 74th pct (bar 60th); hard-hit 40.4% vs pool median 35.7% (at/above = 'decent chunk')	**PARTLY**	whiff is strong (73rd pct), one notch short of 'very strong' on the pre-registered bar
HP-05a	Lots of FF that ride between 12 and 18 inches	FF IVB 10th–90th pct 12.9–16.5 in (max 18.5)	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-05b	[FF] ⟨run about a foot → run about 9 inches⟩	FF arm-side run median 9.5 in (90th pct 12.1 in)	**PARTLY**	runs about 9 inches, a foot only at the top end
HP-05c	His sinker runs up to 18 inches	SI run median 16.4 in, 90th pct 18.6 in	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-05d		ST sweep median 12.9 in; IVB median 2.3 in	**CONFIRMED**	

HP	Claim (client's words)	Evidence	Verdict	Correction
	Sweeper sweeps at least a foot but is fairly flat			
HP-05e	Bullet slider	BS-1r: SL mean	HB	4.7 in, IVB -2.0 in over 70 SL; house line 4.0 / 4.0 in (19 of 110 Phillies RHP slider seasons qualify)
HP-06	vs LHB: 63.4% FF + 27.5% SL	quality K Rate (33%) and ⟨Elite Walks Rate (2%) → Elite Walks Rate (2.6%)⟩	FF 63.4% · SL 27.5% · K 33.3% · BB 2.6% (1 BB in 39 PA)	**PARTLY**
HP-07	vs RHB: 45.6% SI + 25% FF + 15.6% SL + 13.9% ST	Just .179 BAA but lots of hard contact in the underlyings ⟨(41% HH, 9% Barrel) → (41.9% HH, 9.7% Barrel)⟩	mix [45.6, 25.0, 15.6, 13.9] · BAA 0.179 · HH 41.9% · barrel 9.7%	**PARTLY**
HP-08	Plus SL to LHB: 38% Whiff/50% Chase. FF gets 32% Whiff on Swings to RHB. (33% whiff vs LHB)	SL v L 38.1% / 50.0% · FF v R 32.0% · FF v L 33.3%	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-09	McFarlane has elite spin and elite velocity. His fastball is an outlier.	FO-1 (239 RHP FF pitcher-seasons in Phillies games, ≥100 FF): velo 99.4 mph = 99th pct (#3); spin 2544 rpm = 97th pct (#6); seasons at/above on both: 0	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-10	McFarlane emerged as a key plank in the Bridge to Duran	BD-1: 4 of 19 regular-season outings (21%) entered ahead with Duran to follow; first 2026-08-31; all in the last month. Entered ahead 9×; Duran followed 5× (once from a tie)	**PARTLY**	'emerged' fits (every bridge outing came from 8/31 on); 'key plank' is ahead of the evidence (4 outings)
HP-11a	the guy who was drafted in the round following McFarlane back in 2022	McFarlane 4th round 2022 (Miami); Kerkering 5th round 2022 (MLB.com, MLBTR, school sites)	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-11b	Orion Kerkering. Taken in the 5th round ⟨out of Central Florida → out of South Florida⟩	Kerkering pitched for the University of South Florida (USF Bulls)	**CORRECTED**	out of South Florida (USF), not Central Florida
HP-11c	Kerk was rushed to the majors back in 2023 to pitch in leverage situations	log: MLB debut 2023-09-24; 7 postseason outings within his first 10 MLB games	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-11d	During the fateful weekend in Atlanta which cost Rob Thomson his job, Alex McFarlane sat in the Phillies bullpen … He was not needed.	recalled from AA Reading 2026-04-24 before the Atlanta series; Thomson dismissed 2026-04-28; log has no McFarlane pitch before 2026-07-22	**CONFIRMED**	
HP-11e	McFarlane dominated AA for most of 2026	carry-in (MLBTR 7/20): 2.06 ERA, 35 IP, 32.9% K, 12.6% BB, 50% GB at AA; no AA Statcast in the plane	**PARTLY**	dominant on run prevention and strikeouts; the AA walk rate (12.6%) was not
HP-12	Improved command in 2026 brought improved results	no pre-2026 pitch data for him in either plane; AA BB% 12.6% (carry-in) vs MLB 8.2%	**NOT OBSERVABLE**	

Caveats

- Small sample. 85 PA and 333 pitches; every stand × pitch cell is under 50 swings. Read rates as directional.
- Client frame vs governed context. The client's tables include the 2 Wild Card games (as his `pps` does); context percentiles use his 313 regular-season pitches against regular-season pools.
- One automatic ball (9/27, no pitch thrown) is inside the 333 and counts as in-zone in the inherited chase function (AB-1, D-7). It moves the vs-LHB usage shares to a 99.4% total; no headline moves.
- FO-1 is raw velocity and spin, not drift-adjusted (UC #47 drift-adjusts; the order does not change at the top). Opponent pitchers in the pool are identified by MLBAM id only (EN-3: in batting rows `player_name` is the hitter).
- AAA is a supporting tier (counts, usage, velocity, whiff), never blended into MLB rates; AA has no Statcast in the plane.
- Carry-ins (draft, recalls, Thomson dismissal, AA line) are quoted from public sources and never computed on.
- Postseason: 2 Wild Card outings vs Atlanta, 6 PA. Too few to read.

Provenance

UC #63 · `uc-pps-039` · build `dp_uc63` v1.0.0 · kernel `dp_uc63_kernel.py` (imports `dp_uc62_kernel` 2adc60059cfa…, chain asserted at build) · receipts `out/dp_uc63_*` · trail `Agents for Data Products/data-products/uc-pps-039-mcfarlane-2026-recap-001/`. Carry-ins: MLB.com (4/24 recall; 4/28 Thomson dismissal), MLB Trade Rumors (7/20 recall, AA line), University of South Florida athletics (Kerkering draft), Miami athletics (McFarlane).